Brussels goes to Budapest

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, hoping you stay safe on this stormy Friday. Let's get started.

In today's Playbook:

— The EU-Hungary reset rolls on, with Ursula von der Leyen and António Costa in Budapest.

— Kaja Kallas will pledge operational support for the embattled International Criminal Court.

— Faces in the crowd: Manfred Weber, Tomoko Akane, Péter Magyar, Norbert Lins, Aleksandar Vučić, Viktor Orbán, Kristen Michal, Markus Söder and more …

On this week's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Sarah talks to MEP Dirk Gotink and the Atlantic Council's Lize de Kruijf about Donald Trump's sanctions against the ICC and how they play into Europe's sovereignty push.

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DRIVING THE DAY

HOW'S THAT RESET GOING? Ursula von der Leyen and António Costa are heading to Budapest today to mark progress in EU-Hungary relations — but they're not bringing promises to unfreeze any more funds, three EU officials and a diplomat familiar with the trip preparations told me.

Good riddance, Khrushchev (and Orbán): Von der Leyen and Costa are in Budapest to mark the 70th anniversary of Hungary's 1956 uprising against Soviet rule. Von der Leyen will praise the election that ended Viktor Orbán's 16 years in power, while Costa will separately address the Hungarian parliament, Playbook has learned.

Money talks: Brussels unlocked more than €4 billion last month that was frozen during Orbán's rule over concerns about democratic backsliding — but billions of euros remain tied up. Prime Minister Péter Magyar is pushing for the release of the remaining funds, as well as an extra €2 billion from the EU's next seven-year budget to make up for money permanently lost under Orbán's government.

Fat chance: An EU official was scathing about the odds of the latter happening. Everyone wants something from the budget, the official said, but that doesn't mean they'll get it. And while the European Commission is eager to "reward" Hungary by unlocking the cash, it remains cautious, an EU diplomat said. "There's a reason we froze that money."

Taking stock: Almost 200 days after Orbán's defeat, an EU diplomat said there is a "huge difference in style and attitude" under Magyar, particularly around the European Council table. "He isn't trying to make life for the other leaders more difficult." But Hungary's positions on Ukraine and migration remain much the same, the diplomat said, adding it's just that "they are put forward in a different way."

Same sticking points: Magyar is still sometimes obstinate on Ukraine's financing and EU membership, another EU diplomat said. At last week's summit, Magyar and the leaders of other Central European countries said they won't pay interest rates on any new Ukraine loan, angering some of the other leaders, according to two diplomats. (Magyar's representatives didn't respond to Playbook's request for comment.)

A simpler time: Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal told me back in April, on the sidelines of the first leaders' summit since Orbán's defeat, that the mood among leaders was jubilant. "You can feel it," he said. "Everybody's talking about what will happen in Europe next."

Six months on, that optimism has been dented. Brussels remains deadlocked on everything from its €2 trillion budget to energy policy. Those ideological divisions were on full display at last week's summit, which at times devolved into "shouting," two diplomats said — no Orbán required.

BIG AND BREAKING

WINTER OF DISCONTENT: Europeans are raging over the cost of living — and cash-strapped governments from Paris to Rome are helpless to fix the situation.

FRANCE ON EDGE: Emmanuel Macron's government is stepping up security ahead of another weekend of mass demonstrations, with around 70,000 police and gendarmes to be deployed across the country. Tens of thousands of protesters are expected in Orléans alone ahead of far-right leader Marine Le Pen officially launching her presidential campaign on Sunday, Paris Playbook reports.

O NO CANADA: Germany is leading a push against using Ursula von der Leyen's "associate membership" label as the EU negotiates closer ties with Ottawa, diplomats tell Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich.

FIFA ESCAPES A RED CARD: The EU's influential competition regulators have taken on some of the planet's most powerful companies, from Google to Gazprom, but are steering clear of opening a case against football's governing body .

VUČIĆ ON THE ROPES: A student-led movement stands a real chance of edging out Aleksandar Vučić's Serbian Progressive Party in Sunday's parliamentary election, according to an independent poll .

TESTING THE CENTER

WEBER'S CENTRIST RESET HITS A WALL: European People's Party chief Manfred Weber is on a mission to steer his group back to the center and avoid clashes with his traditional coalition partners. While both Renew and the Socialists and Democrats are on board and pushing for a recommitment to the centrist majority in the mid-term carve-up, Weber has a bigger challenge — his own lawmakers, Max Griera reports.

This week's plenary session started out looking promising. On Monday, the EPP struck a compromise with the centrist groups on a car package. Its negotiators could have joined the groups to its right to weaken carmakers' CO2 targets, two EPP insiders told Playbook. (They were granted anonymity, like others cited here, to discuss internal group strategy.) Weber pushed them to cut a deal with the center instead.

That got hopes up: "I am confident in our ability to continue striking deals, including on difficult but sensitive and absolutely necessary issues like this one," Renew chief Valérie Hayer said Tuesday.

But old habits die hard: On Thursday, the EPP joined the right to delay rules requiring fossil fuel companies to monitor and report methane emissions. Tougher tests are ahead, including a Frontex overhaul, an EPP push to reopen the Birds and Habitats Directives and calls to scrap the EU's carbon market.

No strings attached: Several EPP lawmakers say the group should keep its freedom to work with different majorities. One senior MEP said it would continue working with the S&D and Renew "but without conditions." Another called demands for a pledge not to work with the right "not realistic," while a third said they regretted Weber's centrist turn on the cars package.

In response, the Socialists are starting to link files the EPP can pass with the right to legislation where it needs the center left. They're tying support for the cars package to negotiations on the Industrial Accelerator Act and its priorities on that, an S&D official said.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

European Parliament negotiators have reached agreement on what they want to see in the European Competitiveness Fund — but what is that? It's a proposed €400 billion fund to boost industry, research and innovation as part of the EU's next seven-year budget. The European Commission proposed that the fund consolidate 14 existing EU programs covering everything from clean technologies to defense. Many fraught budget negotiations are to come, of course.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

BACKING THE ICC

KALLAS HEADS TO THE HAGUE: Chief EU diplomat Kaja Kallas is visiting the International Criminal Court today in a show of support after the U.S. sanctioned the body , her office told Nick Vinocur.

The EU is banking on being able to negotiate with President Donald Trump's administration to stop the sanctions that are due to come into effect in six months. But Kallas' visit suggests the bloc is throwing its weight behind the court, which won the European Parliament's Sakharov prize on Thursday. It's shaping up to be a major transatlantic face-off.

Operational aid: Kallas touted the EU's "keep calm and negotiate" stance during an address to the Parliament this week. But she's also working to ensure the court can keep operating if the sanctions do kick in, as they already have for 13 ICC officials, including former chief prosecutor Karim Khan. That includes preparing to assist with payments and IT systems "so the court can continue its work."

Backup: Kallas' visit "is a clear show of support," an EU official told Playbook. "The six months period announced by the U.S. offers a window for diplomacy, and we want to find a solution."

On the menu: Kallas will meet with ICC President Tomoko Akane while in The Hague. She'll also drop in on Eurojust and the Council of Europe's Register of Damage for Ukraine , which has already received 200,000 claims over Russia's invasion.

BUDGET CORNER

AGRI GOES ROGUE: António Costa's budget tightrope is already wobbling after EPP lawmakers pushed for extra money for farmers in the bloc's next seven-year budget, Gregorio Sorgi reports.

Costa took over the MFF negotiations last week, but he's already facing a parliamentary revolt in the agriculture committee led by the EPP's Norbert Lins. He threatened to derail negotiations unless Costa puts more money for farmers in the next budget — despite many governments pushing for cuts across the board.

This adds to Costa's concerns as he scrambles to put forward new budget figures ahead of a leaders' summit on Nov. 26-27. The EPP's gripe is that the previous negotiating document from Ireland, which steered the budget talks under its rotating presidency of the Council of the EU, earmarked extra funding for "rural areas" — but offered no guarantees that the money would go to farmers.

Better news from Parliament: Parliament's negotiators agreed to grant companies from non-EU countries access to the €400 billion European Competitiveness Fund if certain conditions are met. More details here for subscribers.

What if your priorities for Europe ended up in a pan-European poll? At the European Pulse Seminar on November 5, you'll have a dedicated moment to say what matters most, and see the room's results revealed before lunch. Apply to join onsite now .

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

REMEMBER 42.7? Cyprus' President Nikos Christodoulides is urging the EU to keep talking about its mutual defense clause, according to a letter seen by Playbook.

GOING AFTER GRAFT: Brussels needs a new sanctions regime that will allow it to pursue corrupt foreign officials, 70 MEPs wrote in a letter backed by campaigner Bill Browder and seen by Playbook's Nick Vinocur.

REVOLT AGAINST RED TAPE: European political foundations are lobbying the Commission and Council to pare back financial compliance obligations they say are too burdensome, Mari Eccles and Max Griera report in this week's EU Influence .

NOT SO GRATE: Italy and France are having cheese problems. Chief fondue correspondent Paul Dallison has more in this week's Declassified column .

DASHBOARD

Scientists estimate that extreme heat killed more than 50,000 Europeans this summer and that climate change was responsible for two-thirds of the deaths. Zia Weise has the full story .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Wind, rain and storms. High of 14C.

FRIENDLY REMINDER: Belgium switches to winter time in the early hours of Sunday. That's one extra hour in bed, but sunset will come an hour earlier. Make the most of the daylight while it lasts.

STAY DRY, FOLKS: Storm Austen will bring severe wind gusts between 60 and 100 kilometers per hour, with rain showers starting this afternoon, Belgium's meteorological institute warns. All Brussels parks and forests will be closed and the fire department is warning against unnecessary travel — so plan ahead.

Diwali festival postponed: The stormy weather has upended plans to celebrate the 10th anniversary of the Brussels Diwali Festival this weekend. The two-day event is now scheduled for Nov. 7-8, still at the Atomium Esplanade.

TIME FOR A CAREER CHANGE? Playbook's hunt for the EU bubble's strangest job ads continues this month — because Brussels careers aren't always as grey as they seem.

Driving diplomacy: Fancy swapping Brussels traffic for Malawi? The EU Delegation in Lilongwe needs a driver to ferry diplomats, deliver diplomatic pouches and navigate difficult roads. Starting gross salary: around €496 a month. Deadline: Nov. 6.

Professional doomscroller: Spend your days scrolling social media and reading POLITICO? The EU's intelligence center, INTCEN, wants an open-source intelligence analyst to do just that — and write security reports. Small catch: You need to already have SECRET UE/EU SECRET clearance. Deadline: Nov. 3.

Yes, chef! The Commission is hiring two chefs de site for its catering operations. But don't be misled: no cooking is involved. Chef de site is a site manager, and the job will be more about supervising canteens than starring in "The Bear" ⋯ although expect a comparable level of shouting in the Berlaymont. Deadline: Oct. 30.

And the award for the longest job title goes to ⋯ Eurostat, naturally. It's hiring a "statistical assistant — international trade in goods statistics — data production (monthly detailed data; data production, validation and quality-control tools)." Yes, that's the actual title . The job? Producing and checking trade statistics. Deadline: Oct. 30.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Center-right Christian Social Union leader Markus Söder heads into the party's annual conference in Munich back on firmer ground — but he's not out of political danger.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron's government is bracing for another weekend of mass protests , while a potential credit downgrade threatens to add to its budget woes.

Madrid: The center-right PP is getting punchier on social media to stop younger voters drifting to the far-right Vox.

London: Chancellor John Healey will promise to save British businesses £800 million a year by slashing red tape in next week's budget.

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AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa deliver speeches in Budapest to mark the 70th anniversary of the 1956 Hungarian Revolution. EBS will carry it live at 2 p.m.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas visits the International Criminal Court in The Hague, where she meets its President Tomoko Akane and Eurojust President Michael Schmid. She'll also meet Markiyan Kliuchkovskyi, executive director of the Register of Damage for Ukraine.

— EU trade ministers continue their informal meeting in Dublin, hosted by Irish Trade Minister Helen McEntee. Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič participates. A press conference is scheduled for 4 p.m. Watch live .

— Coreper I meets at 10 a.m.

— Commissioner Hadja Lahbib meets Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš in Prague.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis meets Latvian President Edgars Rinkēvičs in Riga.

— Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos and Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner meet North Macedonia's European Affairs Minister Bekim Sali in Brussels.

— Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen and Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadis meet Chilean Foreign Minister Francisco Pérez Mackenna in Brussels.

— Kadis meets Vietnamese Agriculture and Environment Minister Trinh Viet Hung in Brussels.

— European Democratic Party's annual congress in Athens, running through tomorrow. Former French Prime Minister François Bayrou, Parliament Vice President Pina Picierno, Greek center-left party leader Stefanos Kasselakis and MEPs Sandro Gozi and Lukas Sieper are among those participating.

— Startups Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva meets Pascal Lamy, president of the Jacques Delors Centre's advisory board, and Geneviève Pons, director-general and president of Europe Jacques Delors.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall addresses an event in Brussels marking the handover of the #HandsOffNature petition by the #HandsOffNature Coalition.

BIRTHDAYS

POLITICO alum Saim Saeed; UNHCR's Matthew Reynolds; DOT Europe's Ana Perdigao; André Ruivo Félix, of the European Disability Forum; Rwandan President Paul Kagame; Finnish Foreign Minister Elina Valtonen. Hungarian Republic Day.

Celebrating Saturday: MEPs Pär Holmgren and Sabine Verheyen; former MEPs Sabrina Pignedoli and Florian Philippot; former Romanian Prime Minister Theodor Stolojan; Bulgarian President Iliana Iotova; Rut Rey of Netflix; Mayor of Autun Vincent Chauvet; POLITICO's Vlad Hosu; Malcolm Turnbull, former prime minister of Australia. United Nations Day.

Celebrating Sunday: Former MEP and POLITICO 28 alum Olga Sehnalová; former MEPs Norbert Erdős and Emilian Pavel; U.S. Embassy in Rome's Stefano Giustiniani; UTOPIA's Brandy Miller.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Gregorio Sorgi and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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